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Pat Caplan

Life story interview with Paul Thompson

2009

Principle investigator's thematic highlights

UK Data Archive, University of Essex, Colchester. June 2017

SN 6226 - Pioneers of Social Research, 1996-2012. Depositor: Thompson, P.
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Pat Caplan

Interviewed by Paul Thompson

18 November 2009

Childhood influences

1: Foreign travel in the family

(p1-2)

I guess I was a child of Empire, and there were so many members of my family who'd travelled very widely – not because they were well-to-do and doing the Grand Tour, but because they had been soldiers or they were migrants. So, for example, my maternal grandmother was born in Australia because her family had migrated there, presumably because of poverty, although they did eventually come back. But there remained an Australian branch, and people would appear from time to time from Australia and other family members would go and visit in Australia. And then my mother's older brother, who had travelled a lot during the War – he'd been in Ethiopia, for example, in the Second World War – he migrated to South Africa when the War ended, and he came back and got married, they went to live in South Africa. So that they'd come on visits, or they'd send photographs, and bring objects. So I always remember all of these houses having lots of objects which were from somewhere else - you know, Indian: both my paternal grandfather and his younger son had been in India – he in the First World War, and my uncle just after the Second World War. So the idea of travelling to places that were very far away didn't seem at all strange. In fact, it was quite enticing. So I guess I got the travel bug early! (LAUGHS)

2: Writing and speaking in the family

(p 5)

I guess [there was] the notion that people were always writing in my house. My father knew how to type, he would sit at home typing the extra articles he did, you know, to

make a bit of extra money to kind of keep things afloat. And, of course, my mother also was a very good typist because she'd been trained as a secretary, in fact she typed my Ph.D. thesis for me, bless her! So this notion that you wrote and you wrote things on typewriters, was just there all the time. And then because my maternal grandfather was a Methodist local preacher, he wrote as well. He wrote sermons. And he had been a member of the `labour aristocracy', he worked for the *Liverpool Post and Echo* as a printer, and, of course, in those days, the days of hot metal presses, printers were highly skilled and not too badly paid. But he too had a family to support, and so he would make money by writing little articles. I have a huge collection of press cuttings of little articles that he wrote – about all sorts of bits and pieces. He'd write them for the *Liverpool Post and Echo* and they'd get published. So he wrote as well. So even though none of them were famous writers in any sense, this notion that you wrote, and you spoke.

And that was the other thing, because, of course, I was also brought up as a Methodist, and went to church at least once, often twice, on Sunday, so I must have listened to more sermons than I care to remember, and so the notion of standing up and speaking in public – some of them were ordained Ministers, some, like my grandfather, were local preachers, and others were just members of the congregation who would have something to say. I think I gave my first public speech in the Methodist Central Hall in Westminster at the age of 14 and, you know, it was just something that people did. I didn't think it was extraordinary! You just did it! (LAUGHS)

3: Parental support

(p3-4)

PT: And what about relationships with your parents and the kind of influence they had on you?

PC: Well, I think they were very profound, because my father had grown up in this small Staffordshire town, and he was obviously quite bright, but there were very few secondary school places, there wasn't a secondary school in the town, you had to go, I think, to Hanley, or Stoke or somewhere, and so the year that he took the exam, they were told there were going to be four places, and, in fact, they got a phone call saying that my father had come in at Number 4, and so he would get to go to the Grammar School, and then

they phoned back and said they were terribly sorry, "We've only got three places and he can't go". So he left school at 14, and he went into the mills, because they had silk mills in Leek. The Huguenots had settled there in large numbers and there was a very big milling industry.

But he obviously was a reader, and there was a children's column in the *Staffordshire Sentinel*, "Uncle Remus's Children's Column", and he entered an essay competition and Uncle Remus – whoever he was – was so impressed that he called him in and offered, through my grandfather, an apprenticeship to be a journalist. Of course, it's unheard of these days for journalists to learn their trade through being apprenticed, but anyway, that's how he did it. In fact, I remember once seeing the Indenture document which was signed by my grandfather, not by my father. So at 16, he went off to learn to be a journalist. I guess he was very frustrated, educationally, because he'd been denied the opportunity.

And my mother equally so, because she was the middle girl of three siblings. The older boy was the one who went off to live in South Africa, and then eventually moved to Canada. And the younger one, who was very much an afterthought child, was my role model. He was much younger than his two siblings, and very very intelligent, and he got a place at Oxford and got a First in PPE, and so everybody would talk of this "wunderkind", and I was going to be like Uncle Walter, I was going to go to Oxford and get a First Class degree and so on! But my mother had been told by her father, after getting a string of very good 'O' Levels that girls didn't need to have an education, and he couldn't afford to keep her on at school, and she was sent off to train as a secretary.

So both of them, I think, when they discovered that two of their daughters were pretty bright, [gave] just incredible encouragement. When I think how supportive they were, and how they struggled sometimes - my father, I remember saying, "Oh, my goodness! More music lessons! More music books!", and my mother saying, "She's got to have it! She's got to have it!" But my father getting up at six in the morning to test me on my Latin, which, of course, he didn't know a word of, but he'd read the English and I'd read the Latin, and he'd say, "Yes, that's right" and so very supportive. They were very proud of me. So that was great. I didn't have a brother, perhaps fortunately, because I think sometimes … where there is a mixed sibling group, sometimes there is [less] support [for girls] possibly. But, no, they were absolutely and completely supportive. I can remember once or twice my father saying, "Aren't you ever going to stop being a student?" as I went on to a Bachelors, and then a Masters, and then a Ph.D.! (LAUGHS)

"When are you going to start earning some proper money?" he'd say! But it was kind of half-joking, and he was very proud. Yeah, so it was a very nurturing and supportive environment really.

4: Women school teachers

(p 6-7)

PT: Which do you think were the significant moments or teachers in school?

PC: Well, thinking about my school, my grammar school – King's Norton Girls' Grammar – they were remarkable institutions, those Girls' Grammar Schools, because, particularly at that time, most of the women who were teachers there were older, and although we liked to laugh at them, and we thought they were all a bunch of old frumps, the situation probably, for many of them, was that they were the kind of remnants of the generation who'd lost fiancés or potential husbands in the First World War, and so most of them were unmarried. But they were very highly educated. Many of them had been to Oxbridge, or the University of London, and teaching was really their life. And I think, particularly for students who they saw as bright and interested, they were willing to do anything really. So there were several teachers who had a very profound influence on me…

5: Meeting foreign students

(p 8-9)

And I had become more and more interested, not just in European culture, but in other cultures, because our Methodist Youth Club went, one day, to a Methodist Student Hostel, of which there are several around the country, called "Methodist International House", and we met up with a bunch, a very mixed bag of overseas students who were studying at the University of Birmingham – [one] was this guy who was my first real boyfriend. But I also met a number of Africans. Anyway, we formed a kind of friendship circle, and we used to go to this Methodist International Hostel regularly at weekends. That must have been when I was 17 and 18, and it was just a complete eye-opener to me, because my

family read the *Daily Express*, which didn't really tell you much about what was going on in the world, or if it did it was a very particular viewpoint. I remember one guy who was from Kenya, who talked about Mau Mau and why Mau Mau, and what had happened with Mau Mau and so on.

And there was another one who was an Indian, from South Africa, and I asked him, because I ran the Debating Society at school, would he come and talk to people at school, to the girls at school who were in the Debating Society, and he said he would. So he came, and he talked about South Africa, and our jaws were just dropping, because this was the period of apartheid at its height and the kind of lives they led, and the restrictions and so on, and what made our jaws drop even more was, at the end, he said, "Please don't tell anybody that I've come and given you this talk". Because, of course, the BOSS – the Bureau of State Security – was very active in Britain, and he would have been in serious trouble. So that was the beginning of a life-long interest in, particularly South Africa, which, I suppose, was one of the great causes for my generation…

They were students at the University of Birmingham, and because I belonged to this Methodist Youth Club, we, a gang of us, had gone to visit them in their Methodist Hostel… So it was getting together with - of course, they were somewhat older than us, they were students, and we were doing our 'A' Levels, but it was a complete eye-opener to a much wider world, and a very different political perspective.

Researching for Ph D in Mafia:

6: Tape recording

(p 20-22)

I remembered that he said to me – Phil Gulliver – he said, "Don't go into the archives, for God's sake!" he said, "because …" and he cited the example of another Ph.D. student who was at SOAS at the time, "He's gone into the archives, and they can't get him out". Because once you started looking at historical records, it was kind of never ending. So I think he was afraid that I would get kind of stuck on that track like this fellow who took forever to finish his Ph.D.! (LAUGHS) So I never did go into the archives until much later, and then, paradoxically, when I got to the archives in Dar-es-Salaam, they hadn't paid their electricity bill and there was no electricity! So you couldn't photocopy, you

couldn't use any of the microfiches and stuff! So, anyway, obviously I shouldn't have gone even then! It was this voice in my ear saying …

The other thing, he was all for being very sensible, and so you had your notebook and pencil, and when I told him I was going to take a tape-recorder, "Oh, I don't know about that, Pat", he said, you know, "just encumbering yourself, and an extra thing to worry about". He was not at all interested in technology and stuff like that. But I did take a tape-recorder into the field, and I had this massive UHER, which weighed a ton. I think it weighed something like 12 lbs, that I used to walk around with it on my shoulder... So I made quite a lot of recordings…

They would have been higher quality, had I not done a foolish thing, which was that I got the longest - there were extra-long play tapes, which, I didn't realise at the time - they lasted for a very long, about two, three hours, each tape, because you could turn them over – but they were very thin. And so some of them deteriorated. When they were digitised, there were some parts, because they were so thin, they would stretch very easily, and then they would get spoilt….

Doing a transcription and then doing a translation is a huge amount of work… It's very, very slow, very time-consuming work. I mean, it's wonderful to have them, but it is a lot of work, especially if you're operating through another language where you've got to do the transcription in that language … well, you should, technically you should, and then you should do the translation afterwards.

7: Salum Ali, cook and helper

(p 26-27)

Oh, well! Of course, when I first went to Tanganyika/Tanzania, those were the days when Europeans always had domestic servants. I didn't really like this idea of having a domestic servant, but I rapidly realised that, unless I wanted to spend all my time fetching water and looking for firewood and all the rest, that would be all I would do. So when I was living in the district capital, he was recommended. He wasn't from that part, he was from the centre of Mafia, but he'd worked for some Indians, because there were quite a number of Indians in East Africa at that time – later, many of them left, the Ugandans were kicked out by Idi Amin, and then a lot of them left Kenya and Tanzania - they left, and some of them have started to come back. Anyway, he'd worked for some Indians

who owned a coconut plantation on Mafia, and we hit it off, and he was, I must say, he was just amazing! He was more like my minder than anything else. He would tell me when I was being idiotic. He was a very good cook. And he was just very nice to have around. And after a while he brought his wife, and she was a marvellous woman, and she also knew a lot about initiation rituals, so all the work I did on initiation rituals was with her help. And they'd never been able to have children together, but they had a little girl who was the daughter of some relative or other, I can't quite remember, called Subira, who also stayed with us, and I was very fond of her. So he was just brilliant.

He was actually the one who introduced me to the man who is the subject of *African Voices*, because I think they'd been on a dhow together. You know, very often youngsters would travel, do a lot of travelling in their youth – they'd go to Zanzibar to pick cloves in the season when cloves were ripe, they'd get work on dhows, it was a kind of time for seeing the world and going up and down the coast – going to Dar, Mombasa, Zanzibar, these areas. So they'd been on a dhow together, and when we got to Kanga, he suddenly realised that this guy, who he already knew, lived there, and that's how I got to know him.

So yes, Salum was just enormously helpful. I mean, he wasn't really a research assistant, I didn't need an interpreter because my Swahili was quite good by the time I got there, and it developed pretty rapidly, but I needed somebody to manage practicalities. And he did sometimes, he'd go and find out things for me, but not very often, it was mainly the more domestic sort of stuff. And to my absolute horror, he died. He was quite a young man. He died a few years after I left the field, and I was really devastated.

8: Mikidadi, younger brother and helper

(p 27-30)

Yes, he was from the village where I'd done a lot of my work. I've worked in several villages, but this is the main one. Actually, he's the person I'm going to write a biography, or a life history of him, and that's what I've just applied for the funding for – to go back and interview people who knew him, and members of his family, to get some additional information. So he was 12 when I arrived in the village, and very, very bright, and he used to come to my house. He was just really curious about me and what I was doing, and books, and so he'd often be around. And when I was going to leave the village

the following summer, of course I was petrified of missing anything, because I'd been told you had to note everything, so I asked several people if they'd keep diaries, and … he said he would. And then I said to this boy, Mikidadi, "Here's a note book, could you write down all the things that happen in the village, and we'll talk about it when I get back". So I was away for a month…. And so I've still got his diary.

When I got back, he said to me, "I'm leaving". And I said, "Oh no! What's happened?" And he said, "My parents have decided I'm not going to get a proper education here, and they're going to send me to Zanzibar", because the standard of education was better, there were better schools, and his older sister and her husband had gone off to live in Zanzibar – because there's a lot of movement and traffic up and down the coast, and there's a big community of Mafians in Zanzibar, so they'd gone there and were living there, so he had somebody he could live with. So he went to Zanzibar, and he did his schooling in Zanzibar….

But there were schemes – this was very much the height of the ujamaa period – where they wanted to train people, it was a kind of barefoot doctors, and people who had got enough of an education to be able to do vocational training in all sorts of things. So anyway, he got sent off on a forestry course, so he spent two years at a forestry institute in the north of Tanzania, in Arusha near to Kilimanjaro, which was run, I think, mainly by Canadians, who obviously know about forests. And so he qualified as a Forestry Officer, and then he got a job as a Tree Officer in Dar-es-Salaam, which he said was incredibly frustrating because there was increasing urbanisation, and people needed fuel to cook their food, and they couldn't afford to have a kerosene stove, so they were forever hacking off the bark from trees, to make them die, so that they could then say, "Oh well, we're just cutting these dead branches". He said, "Trying to preserve the trees in Dar was [impossible]…", it was just a really difficult scenario.

In the meanwhile he had married a rather younger woman, very, very nice woman - with whom I became a very close friend - and they had two daughters and then his father became very sick, and so he kept going to Mafia to try and help out, and sort things out, because there was a sibling group of three, he was the only boy, the other two were girls, so he was the responsible one. And finally his boss said to him, "Look, either you keep your job with us, or, you know, you'd better go and sort out your family in Mafia". And so he said he agonised and agonised, and in the end he just thought the family responsibility was the most important thing, and so he resigned his job, which was, you know, a secure Civil Service job, where you never got sacked, and there'd be a pension at

the end, even if it didn't pay you very much. So it was a very big decision, and he was never able to get another job like that subsequently.

So he kind of managed for many years, and he didn't only have the two girls, he took on the care of six children of his cousin brother, I can't remember exactly how they were related, but we would say "cousin", but he was I think his father's brother's son [I found out later that it was his mother's sisters son] who died suddenly, leaving six kids, and he took them in. And then later, his older sister, who was a very close friend of mine, died in childbirth, and he took some of those kids as well. So he was forever kind of managing, by hook or by crook, bits of money here, little jobs there, to keep the family finances afloat.

He mostly stayed in Dar, but he continued to be very interested in what was happening in Mafia, and he and some other Mafians living in Dar set up an NGO, and tried to get funding from abroad. They did manage to get some CARE funding at one point. They tried to get some Dutch funding, which didn't work. Just to kind of get things moving on Mafia Island, which was a really stagnant backwater. Nothing was happening, except that poverty was increasing. The man cash crop – coconuts – it's a very varied market, but basically, by this time, there were lots of coconuts as a world market commodity. Two things had happened. One is that there were lots of competitors, other areas like Malaysia that were also producing them. And secondly, the reasons why coconuts were wanted for things like using the husks for coir mats and stuff like that, they'd been largely replaced by other artificial products, so the price of coconuts on the whole, although there'd been some times [when] it's gone up a bit, but mostly it's gone down, and it's not in anything like the demand it would have been in Colonial times. So, yeah, so he struggled and wanted to get this NGO off the ground. And it happened a bit, but not as much as he'd hoped.

And he wanted to set up an Islamic secondary school – he was a very devout Muslim – and he wanted a modern but Islamic education, and he said, "We've got to have good Islamic teaching, but we've got to have science labs, and geography and history and everything that the kids need", and so he started fund-raising for that. So he was a very remarkable person, in many ways, who really transcended a very unpromising background, and huge constraints in his life. And we communicated, we wrote to each other for years and years and years, and towards the end, in fact, before he died, we were using e-mail. He had access, he'd go to an internet café and write to me from there. And then in 2002, when I went back for that field trip, I got money to actually employ him,

and it was just wonderful, working with him, because he was really an interlocutor, we could discuss things. We could talk about issues, and I'd never had anybody before who knew the area intimately, but who also was tuned in to lots of debates.

Because one of the ways he used to make money, all these NGOs, the big international - the INGOS – international NGOs – would run seminars, and you used to get paid a sitting fee if you were a local and you went to a seminar. It became a bit of a racket really, but the idea was that you were compensated for loss of earnings, and so he'd go to every seminar he could lay hands on, because he wanted to learn, because he wanted to improve his English, and because he needed the sitting fee. So I think his English must have become pretty good, because he could read - we always talked in Swahili, so I couldn't really judge, but he could read things, increasingly, that I wrote, and ask me about them, and that was just fantastic. That was amazing.

9: Local kinship experts

(p 33-34)

PT: And another thing that interested me was that you said, about people's knowledge of kinship, and that some people know a lot more. Could you explain about that?

PC: Well, these are the people I consulted towards the end, and they would be usually older people, but people who other people would recognise. I mean, you'd need to be older, you'd need to have a very good memory to be able to recite all these genealogies and know how it all fitted together, because you're talking about hundreds of people.

PT: So they recited it in a formal way?

PC: Well, when I asked them, they did. But the other thing is that they would be called on - there's a ritual where you go to the grave, at least once, there's certainly one occasion, there may be more than one in the year. You go to the graves of the ancestors, and you make an offering. It's an interesting event, because it's partly Islamic and partly not. But anyway, you remember the ancestors, and you honour them, and you make a religious offering, and sometimes there's a Koranic reading, but in doing this, you need somebody who knows the genealogies really well, and remembers who these graves

belong to, because these are not graves that have people's names on them, they're just headstones. And so these are the kind of people who would be called on on an occasion like that. They would [also] be called on when there were disputes about land. "Did X have the right to use the land of Y group?" "Was he or she, were they members properly, or had they kind of tried to slide their way in somehow or other, perhaps through being an in-law?" And so these people would be consulted. And they told me that they would try to choose people to pass the knowledge on to, so that there would always be somebody, so it wouldn't die with an old man. They were usually men that I talked to, although some women also had this sort of knowledge.

10: Diaries and letters, and Mohammed

(p 34-35)

PT: Now, the kind of material you collected: you've mentioned the recordings, and you've mentioned these genealogical charts. Were you keeping diaries?

PC: Yes. I had a spiral-bound reporter's type notebook, and I filled 26 of those, and a few other smaller hard-bound ones. And then, in addition, I kept a diary, which again, I've still got – it's up there somewhere – where I would try, most days I wrote something. Occasionally I must have skipped, I guess. But in addition to that – this was not the days of computers and e-mail – and so I religiously, at least once a week, wrote to my parents in some detail, and the letters to my parents are interesting, because first of all I didn't want to worry them, so I would never tell them if I was feeling down or whatever, but I also had to explain things to them, because they weren't anthropologists, they'd never been to Africa. So letters to them are very different than the letters I wrote to Lionel, which I did probably twice or three times a week, where I wrote as one anthropologist to another. And then I was also in letter contact with my two friends, Caroline [Ifeka-Muller] and Janet [Bujra] – the one in West Africa and the one in Kenya – and I still have a collection of their letters, and my letters to them. No. I don't have, this is the pity, which is I don't always have copies of my letters, and the letters that I sent to Lionel, he threw away, at one stage, as in, "I've got to get rid of all this junk!" (LAUGHS) Which is really a pity, but my parents kept my letters, so I have my letters to them as well as theirs to me, and I have Lionel's letters to me, commenting on things I must have said, so

I can reconstruct some of it. So there's all that. And then I had to write a report every three months to my supervisor, so I've got those. And then when I got back, I had to give these three seminar papers, and again, I've got those.

PT: And then you also, I think, you said you got some of the local people keeping diaries or writing about things.

PC: Well, what happened when I got back after that month away was that the diary that this guy, Mohammed, about whom I wrote the *African Voices* book, and his diary was just so amazing, it was so fascinating, and so I said to him, "Why don't you just keep on?" You know, "Would you keep on?" And he said he would. So for the rest of the time I was there, which was - I was away for the month of August, and I had six more months, part of which I was not in that village, so that was extremely useful. And he used to come down to the southern village where I had moved to by that time, and he'd bring the diary and we'd go over what was happening in the village where I wasn't – I was somewhere else now. And then at the very end, I spent a lot of time going through my notebooks, and I had a whole list of questions, and he also came down and worked through these questions with me – you know, things that I needed to clarify.

Then I took photographs. But I have to say my photography, in the first field trip, was abysmal. It was abysmal for several reasons. One is that I didn't have a very good camera, and the other was that the better of the two cameras I had, I dropped in a river… But I have become a much better photographer, and obviously I've got access to better cameras, and cameras which are easier to use, in fact.

PT: And you've kept most of this material, then?

PC: I've kept all of it. Yes. Filing cabinets there, and the notebooks are under there. All my notebooks are there. And the photographs, well, … there are photograph albums of some of the stuff up there. Yes, I've kept it all!

11: Researching in Nepal: the journey

(p 42-43)

PC: We actually went at the end of 1968, and we went via India, so we stayed in Delhi, where we bought our supplies, because, in those days, you couldn't get much in Nepal, so we bought bits and pieces that we needed, in Delhi. And then we flew to Kathmandu, and stayed in Kathmandu for a little while in a German-run hostel for visiting academics - well, guest house, it was. And then we set off for our destination, which was a small town, a district capital called Dailekh, which is in the far western hills of Nepal, and to get there you had to take a plane from Kathmandu to one of the valleys, what's called "The Inner Terai", because Nepal is long and thin, and the bottom part is all lowland flat, but there are some low valleys over the first range of hills. So this valley was called Surkhet, so we flew there, and then we walked for two and a half days into the hills, to reach this town called Dailekh. I mean, we were not in A1 fit shape [at that time], so it would have taken us less time later on, but it's quite a long … you've got to get up a lekh – that's a ridge of about 9,000 feet – and you sleep there the first night, and then you come down the other side of the ridge, and then you go up another smaller ridge, to about 5,000 feet, which is where Dailekh is.

PT: Did you have porters to carry your things?

PC: Yes. We had, we got porters in Surkhet, and I actually found that first walk really difficult, because when I was in Delhi I'd had dysentery, a very bad case, I thought I was going to die, and so I was still quite - I'd recovered from that, but I was pretty weak. And fortunately, we met somebody who had a pony, who was going the same way, and he was very kind, and so he let me use his pony for a few hours, so that helped. So I arrived in Dailekh pretty wiped, really! And this was a small district town on the top of a ridge, a government post where there would be a police post and a little clinic and a school.

12: Husband and wife in the field

(p 42-43)

PC: Well, this was a mixed caste village. Some were Brahmins of one kind or another, and they owned most of the land, and then there were a lot of what are now called "Dalits", and were then called either "untouchables" or "Harijans", who had lost a lot of their land to the higher castes…

I got interested in land and land tenure, and the way this whole process of movement of land away from a much more egalitarian distribution system to one where land was being increasingly concentrated in the hands of the higher castes and why this was happening, and all the kind of changes that were taking place in this village as a result of the wider changes in Nepal. So it was very much a book about social change, and seeing this village as part of a much wider series of entities – the districts, the region, Nepal itself as a whole. I had to have a research assistant, because my Nepali wasn't good enough, and, of course, it didn't improve as rapidly as I would have liked, because I was there with my husband and so we spoke English in the evenings and on our day a week off, again, we'd talk English. I mean, it did improve. By the end of the year I could hold my own pretty well, but I was never as fluent as Lionel was.

Of course, that was the other somewhat galling thing, which is from a situation in East Africa where I'd been extremely fluent and dealt with everything myself, I was put into the "wife" category, and that was harder to deal with because I was very dependent on [him], he did speak very fluent Nepali, and he was an old Nepal hand by that time, and I was a complete novice. So it wasn't always that easy. And the living conditions were quite difficult. I mean, it was physically very arduous because the village where I worked lay - there was about a 2,000 ft. drop and people were scattered over the first 1500 ft., so I had to do a lot of walking up and down, and then the fields, most of them were below that still, so there was a lot of hard walking and climbing, and up and down and all the rest of it.

13: Researching in South India: the influence of Feminism

(p 51-52)

Well, the influences were basically, in a word, "Feminist", "Feminism", which I'd first come across - I remember being in Surkhet and staying in the house of a Peace Corps guy, and he said, "Oh, there's this new book everybody's talking about. Have you read it?" Betty Friedan's *Feminine Mystique*. And I said, "No, I've never heard of it". And he said, "Here. Read it". So we got stuck in Surkhet, and I started to read *The Feminine Mystique*. I think up to around that time – and don't forget, when I got back a few weeks later I found I was pregnant, and I was surprised, because I suppose it was like most babies, a half-planned baby, let's say. Up to that time, I'd always thought it was kind of

the world is my oyster, so although I was aware that being female had certain problems, I thought if you were good enough and clever enough, and you worked hard enough, it wouldn't be an issue. And, of course, once I had a baby, I realised - well, I mean, I'd realised it, to some extent, becoming a wife, but even more so becoming a mother, that it did put a lot of constraints on what you could do, but more importantly, how people saw you. Then I'd had this period that I talked to you about, where my mother and my uncle both were very ill and died eventually, and then I had the care of my very elderly grandparents, as well as having two small children to look after. So I realised that the female lot, in all of these circumstances, which is having children, giving birth, looking after the elderly and so on, is very time and energy consuming. It needs to be done with more support from all sorts of people. But I think I was probably very receptive to the message of feminism, as I could feel myself getting pushed into a sort of wife/mother/housewife role – these were the sort of pressures that were coming, and I didn't like them. I recognised that all those things needed to be done, and I didn't resent doing them one iota, because I'd made the choice to have children, I was happy to have children, I was not happy about what happened to my relatives and their illnesses, but they needed looking after, and so that was okay. But the kind of messages that feminism gave, I think, resonated very strongly with women like me, who'd been very highly educated and who thought that there were no barriers to whatever we wanted to do, and suddenly we discovered with the rude shock of, "It's not quite like that, actually!"

So I got involved in feminism, into feminism in two ways. One was through local groups - consciousness raising groups, book-reading groups - with women who were in kind of the same boat as me, they weren't anthropologists, but they'd all got degrees, and they'd got children the same age as mine, and so that was one thing. But on the other side several of us formed the London Women's Anthropology Group, which met for a number of years, and produced a collection at one stage, and ran a few conferences, and that was very, very important, because we talked about anthropology, and we began to realise some of the kind of biases that it had built in, although, I suppose if I'd thought about it, which I didn't very much, anthropology was attractive as a career, because there were some women who'd clearly made it. When you actually looked at what kind of recognition they'd had, we began to realise that for example, Margaret Mead never had a tenured post. Audrey Richards, who was also a pioneer anthropologist, never got a professorship, and so on and so forth. So that there were limitations, and it was much harder to do whatever you wanted to do. So that was very, very important for me, being

involved in that group, and really re-thinking who I was, what I was, what it meant being a woman anthropologist, and so when I started to think about what I would do on the next research project, I wanted to do something connected with gender, or "women" I suppose we would have called it, in those days. And we had the very strong feeling that women were under-represented, not only in the profession, but also as subjects for study in both sociology and anthropology. And the people who were in our group included people like [Janet Bujra], Diana Leonard Barker, Annie Whitehead, Olivia Harris, quite a few who went on to make names.

And then the third sort of feminist contingent I was involved with were at an Organisation called "The Women's Research and Resources Centre", which was set up in the early 1970s, and I, after all this business with my family had slightly calmed down a bit, I hadn't got a job, so I volunteered my services there two days a week, and there was already Zoe Fairbairns, who's a novelist, she was there part-time, as the only paid worker, and then I joined her as an unpaid volunteer worker. But that was a fantastic experience, because I learnt a lot of things, it boosted my confidence a lot, it was a very interesting place to work, and I met a lot of fascinating people.

14: Researching women's organisations in Madras

(p 56-60)

I was struggling with Tamil, which is not an easy language to learn… And I knew English was very widely-used and spoken in South India, so I needed to do something where at least some of what I'm going to be encountering is in English as well as in Tamil. So I went off to the India Office Library, as it was in those days, which is now the Oriental Collection at the British Library, and started poking around.

And I came across [booklets], what I came to know later very well as a genre, which are called "souvenirs". These are programmes that are produced on certain celebratory and ritual occasions by the kind of women's organisations that I ended up studying. And I thought, "Well, these sound really interesting, here are women doing things, organising themselves, what are the implications of this? What does it mean for domestic relations? What does it mean for their political situation and so on?" So I put in to the then SSRC to do a project on the kind of women's organisations which were clearly very much about social welfare, because they were Ladies Bountiful running the social

welfare schemes for the most part, and I got an SSRC grant. And so off we went to Madras, all four of us, a four-year old and a two-year old, in the early summer of 1974, and it was just a most enjoyable experience. When I told several of my [UK] friends that I was going to study these kind of women's organisations, they said, "You'll be bored out of your mind, and you won't like them" – the people. And, of course, that wasn't true! I was never bored, and I made some really close friends. But I wrote, I ended up writing a very critical book about class cultures, and sub-cultures, and how you maintain privilege through charity and philanthropy and all the rest of it…

And well, the women's organisations that I was working with, I did a survey at the beginning, and then narrowed it down to certain ones that I was going to focus in on, and one of them was a women's club in the neighbouring suburb to where we lived, so that was much more localised, and it became a kind of neighbourhood study as well as a study of a women's organisation. I'm still very close to those people, and I've gone back there time after time and done stuff on ageing and food, and I don't know what else! So there were six organisations that I did in very great detail, and I went to all their meetings, and interviewed all their members many times, and participated in their activities, and read all the literature, then there were another probably half dozen, that I would go to from time to time. And I had a research assistant who did two things. Sometimes she'd go to other organisations, we'd go to different meetings and things, and she'd come back and report, and she would translate Tamil text for me, that I couldn't do for myself…Sushila Krishnaswamy, yeah.

PT: You say in the book that you actually joined some of these organisations. Do you think it's possible to be a neutral participant observer as well as a member of the organisation?

PC: I suppose it's like, it's a bit like NGOs, isn't it, which is that you feel, on the one hand, "Look, these are people who care. They're actually doing something. They recognise that there are lots of problems in the world, and they're seeking to address them in their own way". And the other part of me thinks, "This is not really the answer to anything, this is just a way of people either assuaging their consciences, or …" Well, in the case of the women in Madras, it was very much a middle-class activity aimed at poorer people – usually nameless – and for whom services were provided that were determined from the top, not from the bottom. They didn't ask them, "Do you want this,

that, or the other?" "This is what we think is good for you", and often done in a very ritualistic way, so there would be presentations, very public presentations of clothing or food or whatever by the wealthy, who, of course, were always photographed and named, to the poor, who were always nameless - well, they might be in the photograph, but it would be as "a poor girl receives a dowry for her marriage" or something like that. So, so I had quite mixed feelings about it, but I did make some very good friends.

Because what I actually discovered is that some of these women became extremely politically powerful, and that they had deliberately chosen the route to have political influence, not through the very dirty game of politics, as they saw it, where you can rapidly lose your reputation, but through this much more honourable route, as it was seen - as a social service, social welfare activities – and this gave them access through the Indian Social Welfare Board, first as each state has its own Social Welfare Board, and then India, as a whole, has a Social Welfare Board, and this gives you access to the very top levels of the Planning Commission and Parliament and the Cabinet and all the rest of it. And some women had actually made that jump, at that stage, across into standing for election, or becoming co-opted members of some legislative body or another, and others of them had just stayed … I mean, there was one woman who ran a very powerful organisation in Madras, and when I first heard about her, and I asked who she was, I remember somebody saying to me, "Well, put it like this. The Governor …" – because each state has a Governor, who's the representative of the Delhi Government – "The Governor phones her before he makes any important decision". (LAUGHS) So it was extremely interesting that these very demure-looking Indian women who had all this ideology as a good Hindu husband-worshipping wife, and who would constantly tell me, "Of course I have to be home, yes, I know we've got a cook, but I have to serve him his supper. I have to be there. Actually, they were politicking, some of them, at the very highest level, so it was really a fascinating thing.

15: Ethics for studying up

(p 60)

Well, I suppose it depends who the "up" people are, and whether you - I mean, I didn't agree with a lot of what I saw. The view of the world of some of the upper middle, I mean, they talk about the "lower classes", who were also very often the lower castes, as if

they've come from a different planet, a different species, so although they might feel pity for them, they didn't see them as the same kind of human beings as themselves, many of them, and my whole kind of beliefs about the fundamental equality of human beings and people's rights and so on, was very often affronted by this kind of thing. And yet, on the other hand, in other respects, people were intelligent, fun to be with, you could talk about certain things with them. There were issues we had in common, children and their problems, husbands and the problems they bring, all of that sort of stuff, so it was very mixed.

16: Cakes as modernity

(p 63)

It was when I gave the seminar paper at SOAS soon after I'd returned, and I mentioned the cake-making, and this guy absolutely expostulated, "My God! Are we going to sit here in a seminar and hear about cake-baking!" And, of course, I said, "Well!" and in a later article I wrote something like - because somebody from LSE, which had several South Asianists, had just published a book on "Burning ghats", where they burn the bodies, and the symbolism, and temples and stuff, and I said, "Why is cake-making less important than burning ghats, and temples?" (LAUGHS) Because it [cake-making] has very heavy symbolic significance. It's a sign of modernity, and the cakes are used on certain particular kinds of occasions, and they involve using an oven, which most Indian kitchens, at that time, didn't have, so unless you had enough money to be able to purchase an oven, you couldn't bake a cake. And then improving their English. I mean, I ran an English language discussion group for a long time, which was fantastic for me, because I'd get them to talk about all sorts of things, you know, "Let's do mothers-in-law today", and out would come all this stuff! And they would improve their English in the process. So they wanted to, you know, kind of establish their claims to modernity in a somewhat different way as well as the social welfare…

You see, because this particular suburb, the women were from different caste backgrounds – they were mostly fairly high caste, and most of them were Hindus, there was a sprinkling of Moslems and Christians – so there were certain foods that they couldn't share together, as I discovered somewhat to my cost on one occasion, and the cake-making, this was new, and so it was partly removed from all the very elaborate

grammar which is so much to do with pollution and purity of Tamil cuisine, and some of the rules about commensality, when commensality was permissible and when it wasn't.

17: Mafia: giving back to the community: website and film

(p 73-74)

It's a website for Mafia, it's their website, but I put it up, and it sits on the Goldsmiths' server, and it's quite extensive, because when I was there in 2004, for the first time there was an internet café in the district capital – well, internet café, that's too grand a term! - there were a couple of computers that sometimes worked and sometimes didn't. They were incredibly slow. But I could see this was the way things were beginning to move, and there were a few satellite dishes where they could get international football matches that the boys would gather to watch. In one place in Dar, somebody told me that that was how he got his broadband through a satellite thing, so I thought, "Right, this is the time to do it". So I put up this website, and lots and lots of links which need updating, actually, because some of the links don't work, and there's a lot more stuff available now. And so it was kind of giving back to Mafians.

And then I got money to do a Swahili version [of the Mafia website], so a friend of mine translated everything into Swahili. But there's also a Swahili version of the [2003] film too… It's been shown quite a number of times.

The [BBC] producer, at the end, he said to me, "I've got the rushes. I can give you a copy of the rushes, with all the Mafia stuff all linked up together". Because it was actually chopped into bits in some series that were shown, so there were some quite long sequences and some very short sequences. So the people in the village desperately wanted to see this [1976 BBC] film, and I was incredibly worried because there were some interviews that I knew people had only agreed to, in the film, because they were confidential, so nobody else was there when we shot those interviews, and they didn't mind people in Europe hearing what they were saying, but they didn't want people in the village to hear what they were saying. Very fortunately, it's got a magnetic soundtrack, which means that the sound doesn't appear when it's played on the projectors I'd been able to get hold of on Mafia, which, as you can imagine, are pretty dicey anyway, with the generator and all the rest of it. But the last time I screened it, I screened a video on a

television screen, and there were a thousand people watching a 14" television! (LAUGHS) …

So I guess what I've been trying to do in these later years, is to engage with a different audience. Well, not just an anthropology audience, to try to give back more, but also to engage with a wider audience, and try to show some of what anthropologists do, and what I've been doing. That's become quite important to me.

18: Confidentiality and archiving

(p 82)

Last summer I worked on the archive [of my Madras material], not ready to deposit, but kind of cataloguing it and sorting it, and looking at what there was, and doing listings and all the things you need to do before you archive. And I thought, "This is not going to be easy", because if I gave it to an archive, which is a public archive, these are people who come to London, these are people who read English, the chances are very slight that they would actually go chasing around in an obscure archive to read my Madras field notes, but still and all, some of it is very confidential material. So I think I would probably bequeath it to go after my death or something like that, when most of my main informants will probably be dead anyway as well.

PT: And nobody can get at you!

PC: And nobody can get at me! But Lionel and I had a bit of a debate about the Nepal photographs because we wanted to caption them. We thought that was really important that they're captioned, rather than just photos of a Nepali in 19- whenever. But I wanted to be very careful about names, because of the civil war, basically, in Nepal all these last few years. So what I wanted to do on my photo gallery was to leave off the caste names, but put the other names, so that people could recognise their relatives and ancestors. This whole kind of issue of ongoing responsibilities and confidentiality, and not putting people in a difficult position because you've put something in the public domain, I think they have to be thought through all the time.